

Moeen Ali has witnessed England's cricketing metamorphosis up close. When he debuted in 2014, England clung to tradition.

Today, 'Bazball' has rewritten the script, with Ben Stokes' fearless leadership at its core. In this exclusive chat with *Sportstar*, the former all-rounder reflects on the game's evolution and pitches for a two-tier Test system to keep the format alive and fierce.

England cricket has evolved significantly with Bazball becoming the mantra. What's your assessment?

It's still changing, and they are still going through a process. Obviously, they don't call it Bazball. No one, except for the media, calls it Bazball. But yes, these guys are adapting better now than they were over the last year or so. There has been confidence and stability in the team over the years, and sticking to the players has really, really helped with that. They have just identified players who they know can play and do really well at the top level. And, they are just backing these guys. That's helping the players in a big series like this against India and Australia.

When you started your career, draws were still seen as a result. Now, results seem inevitable. How do you see this new template of Test cricket?

Test cricket has evolved big time. The draws are not good anymore, almost. Unless the teams kind of get to a situation where they can only draw or they have to draw, I just don't think it's the way teams are looking to play anymore. That, in itself, is a skill and an art.

But nowadays, cricket has changed a lot. It has evolved so much that scoring rates, for example, are quicker; batters are

scoring much quicker than probably how they were previously. Not all of them, obviously, but most.

The wickets in England seem to have changed, with flat decks replacing the traditional juicy surfaces. Why do you think that's the case?

The weather has definitely been a factor. While India has been here, the weather has been amazing, which generally makes the wickets slower. That's not what England wants — they prefer bounce and pace. India's bowlers can handle those conditions, but England would still prefer wickets with bounce and pace. When the weather is good, pitches in the UK tend to slow down and flatten out. The Dukes ball has also played a role. Over the last couple of years, it's been quite different — softer and less likely to swing than before, when it stayed harder throughout the game.

What's changed as far as the Dukes ball is concerned?

It changed a couple of years ago. Even during the Ashes, the balls felt slightly different. They used to be heavier and darker, more of a purple-red colour, and definitely harder. That hardness suited both batters and bowlers, seamers and spinners alike.

Even here, although the wickets have spun and Washington (Sundar) took wickets at Lord's, the ball still feels lighter in a spinner's hand, whereas earlier it felt nicely heavy. A heavier ball, I feel, is actually better for spin.

How much of an impact have Ben Stokes and Brendon McCullum had on this team?

Stokes has played a massive role in the team. His impact on the way they play has been huge, better than when I was still playing. They've had many more wins in a shorter period.

Both Stokes and McCullum have identified players who can score runs at this level and handle different types of bowling.

From the start, Stokesy knew exactly what he wanted as captain. Having played in sides that struggled over the years, he had a clear vision and stuck to it, backing himself and his method. He's especially good with younger players, giving them the freedom to play their natural game.

He's been a huge support for someone like (Shoaib) Bashir. Of course, Bashir is there on merit. He's a talented young spinner, but Stokesy's backing ensured he felt no pressure despite outside noise. As captain, he's been that kind of support to many players.

What makes Stokes successful as a leader?

He's a full-on leader. He leads from the front. That's one of his main characteristics. Whatever he wants from the team, he'll be doing it. If he wants them to be aggressive, he'll be the first one to do it. And if he wants them to play in a certain way, he'll be the first one to do so, and then everyone will follow it.

Everyone loves that about him within the changing room, including guys like Joe Root, who have been there probably longer than him. And even if you spoke to Jimmy Anderson, he'd say the same thing. It is love for his captaincy that makes him standout.

With players frequently facing each other in franchise leagues, are bilateral series becoming more predictable?

As a player, you're constantly looking to improve because the guys you share a franchise dressing room with for two or three years will know your weaknesses — both mental and technical. If you struggle with a certain shot, like the drive, they'll pick